

WEEK 12 · PLAY

CLASS 2

The Spaces Play Makes

READING 1

A Prefigurative Politics of Play in Public Places – Carroll et al.

READING 2

“Fugitive Play: The Imaginative World of Northern Black Childhood”
in *Beyond the Boundaries of Childhood* – Webster



Article

A Prefigurative Politics of Play in Public Places: Children Claim Their Democratic Right to the City Through Play

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Abstract

Children have as much “right” to the city as adult citizens, yet they lose out in the urban spatial justice stakes. Built environments prioritizing motor vehicles, a default urban planning position that sees children as belonging in child-designated areas, and safety discourses, combine to restrict children’s presence and opportunities for play, rendering them out of place in public space. In this context, children’s everyday appropriations of public spaces for their “playful imaginings” can be seen as a reclamation of their democratic right to the city: a prefigurative politics of play enacted by citizen kids. In this article, we draw on data collected with 265 children in Auckland, Aotearoa/New Zealand, to consider how children’s playful practices challenge adult hegemony of the public domain and prefigure the possibilities of a more equal, child-friendly, and playful city.

Keywords

play, prefigurative politics, children’s rights, urban public space

The increasing commercialization and privatization of public space (Engelen, Johal, Salento, & Williams, 2014) restricts citizens’ “right to the city” (Harvey, 2008; Lefebvre, 1968; Purcell, 2002), limiting civic access for adults and children alike. However, structures and practices that undergird contemporary Western cities marginalize children in particular (Fincher & Iveson, 2008). Urban spaces are typically designed to reflect adult values (Churchman, 2003; Thomson & Philo, 2004), and social, legal, and physical controls restrict children’s use of public space (Woolley, 2017). Their freedom to independently access and play in their neighborhoods has markedly declined over the decades, and they have been increasingly confined to home, school, and child-specific spaces.

Children are underrepresented in the use of urban space (Woolley, Hazelwood, & Simkins, 2011). They are losing out in the spatial justice stakes (Soja, 2010). As citizens (Haywood, 2012; Larkins, 2014), children have a right to the city (Carroll, Witten, & Stewart, 2017), yet they are often seen as out of place in the public spaces of the city (Freeman & Tranter, 2011; Karsten,

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2005; Kearns & Collins, 2006; Kinoshita, 2009; Matthews, 1995; Valentine, 1996), including its streets. A default planning position largely confines provision for children's play to child-designated areas such as parks, playgrounds, and sports fields (Freeman & Tranter, 2011). Formerly sites for play, city streets have essentially been transformed into adult-only spaces (Karsten, 2005). In addition, open spaces constructed specifically for children can be of limited play and experiential value (Woolley, 2017).

When children have been asked what would make their city a good place for them, having places to play and meet with their friends have been universal responses (Carroll, Witten, Kearns, & Donovan, 2015; Chawla, 2002; O'Brien, 2003). This has been so whether the children were of primary school age (Thomson & Philo, 2004) or teenagers (Matthews, Limb, & Taylor, 2000; Valentine, 1996). Yet safe and welcoming spaces in cities for children to play, explore, or simply hang out are often scarce. In addition, children are increasingly surveilled, supervised, and controlled (Furedi, 1997; Prout, 2000), and their freedom of movement in the public domain is restricted by design, decree, and safety concerns—particularly traffic and stranger danger (Carroll et al., 2015; Carver, Timperio, & Crawford, 2008; Freeman & Tranter, 2011; Karsten, 2005; Shaw et al., 2013; Skår & Krogh, 2009).

Research from a range of academic fields highlights the importance of access to the public domain and free play (as opposed to play activities controlled and supervised by adults) for children's well-being (Alexander, Frohlich, & Fusco, 2012). There is a shared belief among experts that free play is an integral component of learning and child development—that is, it is important for children's cognitive, physical, and social development; the formation of a healthy sense of identity and belonging; and for their later health as adults (Christensen, 2003; Gray, 2011; Loebach & Gilliland, 2016; Woolley, Spencer, Dunn, & Rowley, 1999). During free play children learn to overcome fears, solve problems, take control of their own lives, and make friends. Lack of access to places to play creates "significant challenges" for children's well-being and healthy development (Loebach & Gilliland, 2016; Woolley, 2017).

Despite an overall decline in children's presence in the city, some children continue to play and hang out anywhere and everywhere including the street. In doing so, they challenge positions and identities conferred on them by adults (e.g., Valentine's [1996] archetypes of "angels" in need of protection or "devils" requiring containment) and utilise "adult" public space for play, subverting adult-coded purposes and bringing into being "alternative imaginings of space" (Lester, 2010, p. 3; Kearns, Carroll, Asiasiga, & Witten, 2016). In doing so, they engage in the politics of childhood (Kallio & Hakli, 2011).

Children as Citizens and Political Agents

Children's rights as citizens are enshrined in the 1989 United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC) (United Nations, 1989), including their right to protection, their right to be included in decisions about matters of importance to them, and their right to play (Davey & Lundy, 2011). Prout (2000) and other commentators have highlighted tensions between the acknowledgement of children's rights to protection on the one hand and the acknowledgement of their individual agency/self-realization on the other. All too often children's rights are couched in terms of the right to protection and to preparation "for their future as adult citizens" (Fincher & Iveson, 2008, p. 109).

Concepts of citizenship—and what might constitute children's citizenship—differ (Fincher & Iveson, 2008; Haywood, 2012; Jans, 2004; Larkins, 2014; Thomas & Percy-Smith, 2010). Jans (2004) categorizes citizenship variously as an "identity," as a "state" (with specific rights), and as a "practice." Thomas and Percy-Smith (2010) refer to the "dynamic process" of participation inherent in the latter. While children's rights are recognized through the identity and state of citizenship, their citizenship is expressed through the dynamic process of participation—whether

through engagement with formal political structures and processes or in their mundane embodied practices—to benefit “their own lives and their communities, and create a better future” (Thomas & Percy-Smith, 2010, p. 3).

Children are readily recognized as political actors when they participate in formal political structures such as the youth parliaments, councils, and advisory groups, which have proliferated since the widespread adoption of the UNCRC (Tisdall, Davis, & Gallagher, 2008), or are part of advocacy groups or protest movements (Percy-Smith & Burns, 2013; Shier, 2010). But they are also “political actors in their practices of everyday life.” As they interact with adults, peers, and their physical environments, their lived worlds are “potential fields of political action” (Kallio & Hakli, 2011, p. 100). Children’s everyday political acts include their play in the public domain—“their willingness to challenge positions and identities offered to them by adults [. . .] and abilities to negotiate and occupy unsupervised space” (Kallio & Hakli, 2011, p. 107).

Children’s propensity to play anywhere and everywhere challenges adult hegemony of the public realm. It also has the potential to prefigure a more equal, child-friendly, and playful city—a city with diverse affordances that invite play (Kyttä, 2002, 2004) and where children can feel safe and welcome, meet friends, and play.

Prefigurative Politics and Play

The notion of prefigurative politics—the term was coined by Carl Boggs in 1977 (Yates, 2015)—has been used to describe a wide range of political and social actions that have sought to embody, enact, and “prefigure” a desired future social order. These include feminist, indigenous rights and environmental movements, along with a variety of antihierarchical mobilizations (Jeffrey & Dyson, 2016), and attempts by adult citizen-activists to reshape urban space and reclaim their right to the city (Hou, 2010; Iveson, 2013). Prefiguration “forms part of a general understanding of politics as an instrument of social change” (Yates, 2015, p. 2). It seeks to model the future through a “politics of the act” (Trott, 2016, p. 266), implementing new and transformative ways of living, communicating and occupying space. Prefiguration may also extend beyond intentional social movements and established political networks and organizations to everyday practices, places, and settings (Cornish, Haaken, Moskovitz, & Jackson, 2016; Guerlain & Campbell, 2016; Williams, 2017). Cornish et al. (2016) invite us to “see emancipatory politics where we might not previously have seen them” (p. 123). Guerlain and Campbell’s (2016) analysis of a community garden project in East London is an instructive example: although the gardeners do not conceptualize their activities as political, their efforts are prefigurative, in that they “combat the multiple forms of deprivation that define their daily lives and, in the process, discover wider existential possibilities” (Cornish et al., 2016, p. 121). Similarly, children may not conceptualize their play as political. However, we consider mundane instances of children’s public play as potentially political and prefigurative in that they “enact in the present a future which is desired,” and entrain “new forms of sociality to prefigure or support the emergence of not yet knowable ‘better’ ways of living” (Cooper, 2016, p. 453)—in this instance, a fairer, more child-friendly and playful city.

In arguing for the prefigurative possibilities of children’s play, our focus is on free, or informal, play: “an activity engaged in for enjoyment and recreation . . . it is informal, spontaneous, and uses both body and mind” (Auckland Council, 2017c, Foreword). Free play is intrinsically motivated, pursued without external reward, and inspires imagination and creativity (Alexander et al., 2012). In addition, children’s free play involves “an intimate relationship or disposition to their immediate environments . . . a desire to disturb things, and to inject surprise into the mundane practicalities of everyday experiences” (Lester, 2010, p. 2). Children become creators and actors, transforming their environments. From children’s perspectives free play includes “hanging out” with friends—“‘having a laugh,’ chatting, gossiping and simply being in a place to see

and be seen” (Thomson & Philo, 2004, p. 116), and also “just walking” (Horton, Christensen, Hadfield-Hill, & Kraftl, 2014). In two Canadian studies exploring children’s ideas of play, participants saw play as an end in itself, something fun and pleasurable (Alexander, Frolich, & Fusco, 2014); and almost anything or anywhere was an opportunity for play or to hang out with friends (Glenn, Knight, Holt, & Spence, 2012). In an earlier Scottish study, the “street” (which included, following Matthews et al., 2000, roads, alleyways, walkways, shopping areas, waste ground) trumped backyards and play parks as children’s preferred outdoor space for play and hanging out (Thomson & Philo, 2004).

Not only do children have a propensity for play, but they also, suggests Freeman (2017), have a propensity for happiness; and having fun is “happiness at its most evident” (Freeman, 2017, p. 90). Play, fun, and happiness are intertwined, and the spatial attributes of cities that promote play are likely to also be those that promote happiness—spaces that “support play and independence, access to other children and people, and safe environments” (Freeman, 2017, p. 94). Skår and Krogh (2009, p. 343), differentiating children’s spontaneous and self-initiated play from adult-controlled, planned, and organised activities, draw on Heidigger’s view of children’s play as a fundamental exploration of the environment, which is characterised by the “exploration of that which happens, and can be termed a ‘space’ of possibilities.”

Children’s prefigurative play points the way toward the possibility of a more playful, child-friendly city that promotes happiness and well-being. What is required is a shift from attempts to confine children’s play to a few child-specific spaces, to re-imagining streets, squares, and parks as sites for children as well as adults. This requires both conceptual and planning practice changes. In recent years, adult citizen-activists have moved to reclaim their democratic right to the city through everyday resistance, do-it-yourself urbanism and guerrilla urbanism, and insurgent citizenship movements (Hou, 2010; Iveson, 2013). While adult movements offer overt examples of prefigurative urban politics, which “critique the status quo” and suggest “radically democratic practices” for greater social justice (Cornish et al., 2016, p. 114), we argue that children’s play in public places can also be seen as a form of prefigurative politics, “opening up new possibilities of being, seeing and doing” (Guerlain & Campbell, 2016, p. 220).

Study Context

Auckland is New Zealand’s largest and fastest growing city. The population of 1.4 million—300,000 of them children—is expected to reach 2 million in the next two decades. City planners are striving to contain low-density urban sprawl and accommodate the larger part of the city’s future population in higher density housing (Auckland Council, 2012, 2017d). While stand-alone suburban houses with backyards remain the norm for families with children, increasing numbers of children are now living in apartments. Residential intensification profoundly affects children’s everyday lives and well-being, contracting private living and leisure space. This, coupled with child-blind urban planning (Randolph, 2006), is accelerating the loss of play space for children (Freeman & Tranter, 2011; Kearns & Collins, 2006). New Zealand signed the UNCRC in 1993, recognizing children as citizens with rights to participate in decisions about matters affecting them and their right to play. In 2010, the Children’s Commission questioned whether the country was meeting its obligations under the convention, noting a lack of accessible, safe public spaces for children to play (Children’s Commissioner, 2010). Eight years on, the concern is still valid.

Being out and about and playing in the public domain, once considered “a rite of passage of childhood” (Alexander et al., 2014), has decreased in New Zealand as elsewhere (Carroll et al., 2015). So has that other childhood “rite of passage”—walking to and from school (e.g., Ministry of Transport, 2009; Shaw et al., 2015). This has affected opportunities for free play as walking to and from school affords many opportunities for play along the way. The role of parental fear and

societal safety discourses is clear. A 2015 survey of 2004 Auckland parents showed that while 91.5% believed that roaming independently in the neighborhood was good for children (because it helped them find their way around and allowed them to meet and play with other children), less than 50% believed that children younger than 13 years should be out and about without adult supervision if they were alone (or 11 years old, if with friends)—because of fears for their safety (Duncan & McPhee, 2015). In a subsequent 2017 Auckland Council survey of 2675 Auckland parents, 40% wanted their children to be able to play in suburban streets and close-to-home open space. At present only 23% allow this because of safety fears (Auckland Council, 2017a). Adult-supervised formal leisure activities for children are in many instances replacing informal play and “hanging out,” in Auckland as elsewhere (Carroll et al., 2015; Freeman & Tranter, 2011; Kearns & Collins, 2006). The 2017 survey identified that 77% of parents were in favor of the council introducing playful elements to the city (Auckland Council, 2017a).

Method

A total of 265 children aged 9 to 12 years living with their families in nine suburban and inner-city Auckland neighborhoods were recruited from local schools as part of a mixed-methods study exploring children’s independent mobility, physical activity levels, and neighborhood perceptions (see Oliver et al., 2011, for full methodological details). After seven days of collecting quantitative data (using accelerometers, global positioning systems, and self-report travel diaries), go-along walking interviews (Carpiano, 2009) were conducted with 140 of the children. Each child took a researcher or, in some instances, a trained young interviewer from a local school (aged 17–18 years) on a neighborhood walk, talking about where they went and what they liked to do. Parents were also interviewed about their neighborhood perceptions (Witten, Kearns, Carroll, Asiasiga, & Tava’e, 2013). Follow-up school-based focus groups with 32 of the suburban participants (see Oliver et al., 2014), and a similar number of inner-city participants (see Witten, Kearns, Carroll, & Asiasiga, 2017), further explored children’s neighborhood perceptions and play. All individual and focus group interviews were recorded, transcribed, and thematically analyzed.

Findings

Analyses of quantitative data and parent interviews previously reported on (Carroll et al., 2015; Witten et al., 2013; Witten et al., 2017) show that parental fears of traffic and “stranger danger” limited children’s ability to be out and about in the public realm, with less than half travelling unsupervised to and from school. However, unsupervised play on streets adjacent to their homes, and walking to the local dairy (convenience store) or a nearby friend’s home, remained common practices for many. The street (including pavements, verges, alleyways, car parks, shops, and malls), and stairwells and corridors in apartment buildings, were valued as play space. Children from lower socioeconomic neighborhoods were more likely to be independently out and about—and less likely to be involved in formal extra-curricular leisure and sporting activities—than children from higher socioeconomic neighborhoods. This supports Elsley’s (2004) contention that the street remains an important play space for poorer children in particular. A few children—with or without express parental permission—roamed widely in their neighborhoods and beyond.

Like Skår and Krogh (2009), we have taken a phenomenological approach in analyzing data from the go-along interviews and school-based focus groups, describing interactions between the children and the affordances (Kytä, 2002) in their urban environments that invited play. It has not been the intention to either catalogue the types of games played (already done by researchers, e.g., Iona and Peter Opie, 1969, 1997) or quantify the numbers of children involved but rather to illustrate discrete examples of play that would be considered prefigurative. Our

examples are organized into three sections, corresponding to three forms of children's use of public city spaces, each carrying the potential to disrupt and reconfigure the dominant adult order of the public realm.

Deliberate Repurposing

Here, children actualize affordances around them (Kytä, 2002), recruiting objects and spaces for their own "alternative imaginings." They set about transforming and repurposing these spaces for play, disregarding—and subverting—primary, adult-coded purposes of streets, car parks, and corridors. The surfaces of footpaths and pavements became valued sites for ball games, riding bikes and scooters, and skateboarding (Woolley et al., 2011). A particularly smooth-surfaced road or pavement was valued for rollerblading, a kerb or irregularity in the pavement good for doing "tricks" on scooters or skateboards. These usages challenge the primary purpose of roads and pavements as efficient thoroughfares for pedestrian, automobile, and other through traffic.

Car parks, constructed for workers and shoppers' cars, and integral to the commercial enterprise of the city, became courts for badminton and tennis and other ball games or spaces for bike riding, rollerblading, and scooting. Sometimes children played in between and around cars, or they waited until the workers or shoppers had gone home, leaving an open space for play.

A boy (10 years old) described learning to rollerblade in a neighborhood car park, weaving around parked cars.

Right next to my house is a Blank Electrical and there's a car park, and my sister goes rollerblading there . . . [and] she taught me how to rollerblade.

Once workers had left in their cars, another car park with a high wall, adjacent to her apartment block, was described by a girl (11 years of age) as her favorite place to play and hang out with siblings and friends.

Once [in the weekend] we played from 10 o'clock, we had a break and then started playing again at 1 o'clock and we finished at about 6 o'clock.

Walls were no longer for privacy or demarcating private property but for climbing on or bouncing balls off. A girl spoke of a boundary wall in front of a house she passed on her way to school each day that she always climbed up on, walked along to the end of, and then jumped down from, because "it's fun." For one boy (10 years of age), any wall was an invitation to climb:

Ah, I only jump on walls and stuff like that if I'm with my friends and if I want to. Ah, I do it most times.

Manhole and inspection covers on city pavements, providing access to the underground services of the city, became triggers for playful action and reaction. One boy (12 years of age) explained the code: for instance, FH (fire hydrant) was "first hit" and WH (water hydrant) "whack me"; standing on a V (street valve) earned a vampire-like grip around the neck and a T (telephone equipment), a taser-like jab to either kidney (see examples in Figure 1). Several children from the same inner-city school spoke of playing this particular game. The adult-coded function of these manhole and inspection covers was transformed by the children in their playful interactions as they walked to various destinations or hung out together on the street.

Children living in apartments co-opted access routes such as corridors, stairs and foyers, and service areas under stairwells as play spaces. They described playing soccer in corridors, tiggy on the stairs, and contained ball games in and under stairwells. In one instance, the space under a stairwell was popular for circling a hula hoop.



Figure 1. Fire hydrant, also known as “first hit” and street valve, also known as “vampire.”
Photos taken by the authors.

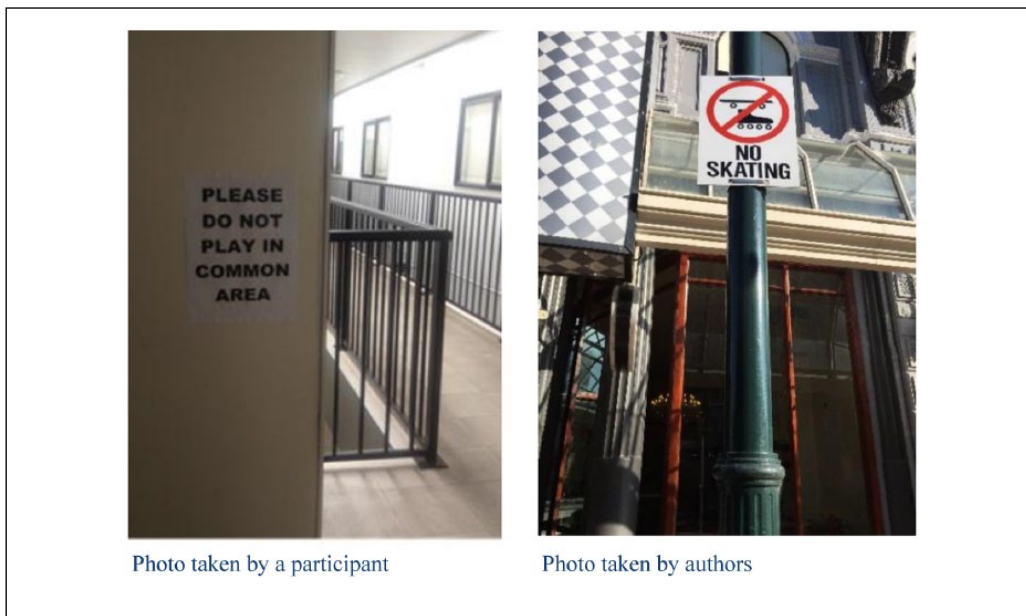


Figure 2. Contesting children's play.

We play soccer in the hallways (boy, 10 years).

Under the stairs there is a big space [where] sometimes we play with a ball and sometimes with a hula hoop (girl, 10 years).

These playful appropriations did not go uncontested. The girl (12 years) who took the “PLEASE DO NOT PLAY IN COMMON AREA” photograph in Figure 2 lived in an inner-city high-rise apartment block:

We used to play hide and seek and tag in the corridor but then the manager had calls complaining about the noise. . . . Now there are signs on each floor telling us we can't play there.

Such signs discouraged children's play but did not stop it.

Playful Presence

Here, children's incidental play has the potential to disrupt adult purposes. Examples include the games that children played on the pavement as they walked to school and other destinations, clambering over fountains and other urban features, and climbing roadside trees. These playful activities were often opportunistic rather than deliberate, and yet they had similar prefigurative potential to subvert existing, adult meanings and purposes. On a go-along walking interview with one boy (10 years), we traversed a small green space providing a shortcut between two shopping blocks at a busy intersection. In the middle was a sculpture of large rocks, topped with a fountain. Oblivious to the flow of pedestrians, he clambered on to it. He always does, he says.

I climb up on a rock to see what I can see and sometimes I dance around. (He shows me)

And then what?

Then I climb up on another rock and dance around.

His focus was not on getting from A to B but on the opportunities for fun and play along the way. These frequent after-school excursions in the shopping precinct were taken without parental knowledge or permission.

Many children spoke of the games they played while walking to school and other destinations. They ran, spun, and skipped; balanced on walls and kerbs; and avoided cracks and jumped over shadows.

On the way to school there's these shadows and me and my brother used to have this thing we used to jump over, so we wouldn't stick in the shadow. If a car would drive by there would be a shadow on the [footpath], so we had to jump over the shadow (boy, 10 years).

Yeah, and we have another thing where we don't step on a crack (boy, 11 years).

When I walk home [from school] I just do turnarounds. I spin (girl, 9 years).

Boys in particular talked of play fighting as they walked.

I kind of play around with my friends. Ah, stuff like play fighting. Um, then that's mostly it (boy, 11 years).

Some boys also acted out computer game scenarios, bringing virtual reality into their outdoor play.

Everyday afternoon I play Call of Duty in the computer, and at five till seven I play in the field. By myself, I'm imagining it. There's tanks, me dying. And having another life again and again (boy, 10 years).

Trees lining streets, planted for shade and aesthetics, were especially inviting. Both girls and boys talked of climbing trees.

I like climbing trees . . . you get to see friends when you're up in the trees (boy, 10 years).

I feel safe in the trees for some reason. Even though it's high and I could get badly hurt from falling down, I just feel safe at the top of trees where it's high (girl, 11 years).

Just Hanging Out

Alongside more imaginative forms of prefiguration, children also asserted their right to the city through conventionally using and hanging out in public places seen primarily as the domain of adults, such as streets and shopping malls. Streets provided opportunities to “walk and talk” with friends and to look at people, gardens, graffiti, shop displays, and cafes, just as they do for adults. Children also “just walked”—sometimes by themselves and at other times with friends. Several talked of walking around the block for “something to do.”

Sometimes if I’m really, really bored, I would just like go around the block, like this area for like fun (boy, 12 years).

I love looking in the shop windows cause they’ve always got different displays like in a month, every month . . . they’re like all themed . . . and they’ve got some cool and quirky shops here (girl, 11 years).

Shops were the most frequent destinations for children—apart from school—and the local dairy (or convenience store) their most favored one. Many of the children were allowed to go unaccompanied to their local dairy, and they often spoke of being on friendly terms with the shopkeepers (Carroll et al., 2015).

The dairy, the dairy. I go there lots . . . yeah (boy, 10 years).

Me and S go there quite a lot. We’re quite good friends with them, so, um, sometimes they give us free lollies (girl, 11 years).

The local mall was also a favourite haunt for hanging out.

It’s gangsta (boy, 10 years).

I go there three or four times every week (girl, 11 years).

Perhaps because our cohort were preteen, none of the children reported being hassled by store-owners or security guards (Matthews, 1995; Woolley et al., 2011).

Discussion

While the built environment, coupled with protectionist discourses of safety and risk (Witten et al., 2013), restricts children’s presence and play in the public domain, our findings highlight the nascent properties of play. There is always potential for it to break out anywhere and everywhere, prefiguring the playful potential of public spaces as it does so. As Woolley et al. (2011) note, children and young people use public space “in ways which were not imagined by the original designers” (p. 472), challenging adult norms and cultural forms.

In this article, we have looked beyond what might be easily recognizable as “politics” and those who might be most readily recognizable as “political actors” to what nevertheless carries the “potential for broader forms of social change” (Cornish et al., 2016, p. 120)—in this instance, how children’s play in public places might prefigure a more playful, child-friendly city. Like more overt political prefiguration, children’s play is “experimental and experiential” and children’s disturbances of the “adult” city entail the “occupation and re-composition of public spaces” (van de Sande, 2015, pp. 189-190). Through their play, children “rehearse their political selves as self-governing actors who are able to resist dominating power structures” (Kallio & Hakli, 2011, p. 100) and model a vision for the future through acts of play (Trott, 2016).

Children's willful appropriation of public spaces and objects around them for their alternative imaginings can be seen as "deliberate repurposing". Here, their active play subverted primary, "adult-coded" purposes of streets, corridors, and car parks. In other instances, children's incidental play on the way to school and other destinations, and "playful presence," had the potential to disrupt adult purposes. Alongside these more active forms of prefiguration, children also asserted their right to the city through "just hanging out" in public places seen primarily as the domain of adults, such as streets and shopping malls. These everyday appropriations of public spaces can be seen as a reclamation of children's right to the city: a prefigurative politics of play, albeit nonreflexive (Cornish et al., 2016; Guerlain & Campbell, 2016), enacted by citizen-kids.

For children's right to the city to be fully and formally actualized, they need adult-led processes and adult champions—that is, researchers, planners, designers, and legislators who recognize children's right to play. Urban planning practice can be child blind and restrictive (Freeman & Tranter, 2011; Randolph, 2006; Woolley, 2017), with attempts to control children's use of public space through design or by decree. An example here is skateboarding, where efforts are frequently made to confine it to specific areas in the community (e.g., skate parks) and to "design out" skateboarders from other areas (Woolley, 2017, p. 99). Sometimes signs also explicitly prohibit the use of skateboards, as they do other children's play. In our own research, a participant described and photographed a sign attempting to ban children from playing in common areas in a high-rise apartment building (Figure 2). Such clashes can lead to a push and pull of rights, where adult/managerial enforcement of "no skateboarding" or "no playing" collides with children's play.

There is a powerful prefigurative potential to children's play at a point in time when the tide appears to be turning, and children's right to the city recognized, at least in some jurisdictions. For instance, encouraged by the UNICEF's Child Friendly Cities initiative (UNICEF, 2018), children are being included in the design of public space in some cities across the world (Fotel, 2009; Malone, 2015). There are a few nascent signs of this in Auckland. Planners and policymakers are beginning to look to children to explain—and to show—how spaces might be transformed for play. Dissemination of our research findings on children's use and experience of Auckland neighborhoods (Carroll et al., 2015; Witten et al., 2013), coupled with a desire within Auckland Council to gain UNICEF child-friendly city status, led to the Council requesting a child-friendly audit of an inner-city square due for redevelopment. Through this audit process, children's rights to access public space and their participation in public realm decision making were acknowledged and their ideas for a playful square incorporated into the final design (Auckland Council, 2017b). The initial design brief had not even considered children as potential users of the square. As a follow-on from this consultation, the authors are involved in facilitating two further co-design projects in collaboration with Auckland Council and the development of a co-design "tool kit" for planners. Auckland Council is also investigating ways some city car parks can double as "pop-up" play spaces. These nascent changes show the transformative possibilities of children's irrepressible desire to play anywhere and everywhere.

Postscript

Donoff and Bridgeman (2017) note the "largely untapped potential for urban environments to act as play space for all." Children's playful practices in the public realm suggest possibilities for the creation of more playful, child-friendly cities. The authors note how our own perceptions of mundane elements of our urban environment have changed through observing and talking with children about their play in the public domain: street trees are sized up for their climbing potential, low walls might present balancing possibilities, and pavement surfaces and kerbs register as good for scooter riding and skateboarding—or not. And as we walk the city streets, the myriad manhole covers, big and small, round, oblong, and square—and hitherto largely unremarked—inevitably attract our gaze. They conjure up a whole world of play.

Beyond the Boundaries of Childhood: African American Children in the Antebellum North | Webster

Week 12, Class 2

Chapter 1: Fugitive Play — The Imaginative World of Northern Black Childhood — pp. 14–35

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CHAPTER ONE

Fugitive Play

The Imaginative World of Northern Black Childhood

During his time at the Shelter for Coloured Orphans in Philadelphia from 1827 to 1832, Stephen Ricks greatly impressed the adults around him. He displayed behavior and intelligence that was “uncommon” and “unusual.” Ricks was drawn to school and favored learning over leisure. He “seldom inclined to mingle with other children at play,” and rarely left the schoolroom during the hours of recess. Instead, he preferred “retirement in pen and book.”

These descriptions of Stephen Ricks were primarily provided by white female reformers and observers concerned with the education and care of orphan children. These adults encouraged Ricks’s “mature” behavior and praised it publicly in their annual report to the Association for the Care of Coloured Orphans.¹ Indeed, the white administrators of the Black orphanage idealized his childhood, representing him as a model of how Black children *should* behave. But his legibility as a Black child did not fit the dominant definition of childhood, which celebrated white children’s play and innocence. With his true desires and sensibilities mediated through these adult eyes, Ricks was described as adult-like, intellectual, pious, and reserved.

Individually and collectively, Black children like Stephen Ricks confronted constraints placed upon them by dominant cultural ideas about childhood, white reformers’ institutionalization of Black children, and Black activist notions of respectability. While normative notions of nineteenth-century childhood became enmeshed with behaviors of play and states of innocence, Black children like Stephen Ricks navigated social constructions of childhood from which they were increasingly excluded. Their evolving statuses of enslavement, indenture, and institutionalization placed them in a constant state of contradiction and pathologization. They were seen as mature yet too childish, too playful yet naturally suited for labor. Nonetheless, Black children imagined possibilities beyond limiting notions of childhood. Through their play, Black children challenged nineteenth-century white reformers’ appropriation of their labor and surveillance, as well as Black middle-class/elite representations of childhood. Northern Black children’s

behavior and actions reveal the tensions between discourses on white childhood, idealized Black childhood, and the paradoxical nature of race and childhood.

As a group that straddled many social and legal boundaries, northern Black children strategically attempted to adhere to popular ideas about how children should behave. Moreover, their active and figurative play allowed them to navigate and challenge the physical and social boundaries of childhood. While northern Black children's playful behavior is elusive within historical documentation, their play nonetheless haunts the archive of childhood itself. It has been intentionally, and at times strategically, obscured within literature, institutional records, and archival objects related to children.² Black children themselves were marked by contradictory, racialized ideas about labor, play, innocence, dependence, and freedom. Play was (and remains) a way in which Black children worked through the metaphysical dilemma of childhood.

Throughout the antebellum period, Black children living in the U.S. North were impacted by cultural legacies and historical events, including the Middle Passage and migration, slavery and emancipation, and the coming of the Civil War. These processes and events influenced modern notions about childhood that emerged during the early part of the nineteenth century as an important element of a white middle-class identity that valued childhood innocence and play. Although the practice of play held special significance in the home, it was institutionalized through the designation of spaces and objects for Black children's play. During the nineteenth century, whites admitted Black children into various orphanages and reformatories, but also challenged the basic premise of their childhoods. They indentured Black children instead of educating them, and only allowed them access to specific playful experiences if they African American children exhibited appropriate behavior. Simultaneously, white and middle-class children received formal schooling for longer periods of time, which in turn limited their required labor contributions to their families and encouraged playful exploration.³

The transatlantic slave trade impacted how northern Black children were treated in the antebellum era and produced a legacy of pejorative characterizations of Black childhood based in white supremacy. On the African continent, capture and the march to the sea disrupted prevailing experiences of childhood. As white slavers forcibly transported children of African descent across the Atlantic, the children's notions of their own identities evolved. European traders and slavers oppressed child-bodies with little or no regard to social and cultural beliefs. European models of childhood were also evolving

during the era of the transatlantic slave trade, and Europeans marked enslaved children as the *other* from which they defined normative notions of children from the moment of capture to sale and enslavement. Yet from the moment of capture to sale and enslavement, Black people in the African diaspora articulated their own childhoods by retaining elements of West African identity—and reframed the ways in which childhood was defined in the New World.

While West African recognition of the child varied across cultural landscapes, records of shared beliefs in precolonial Africa indicate that children—a category not necessarily defined by age but by spiritual, cultural, and physical stages—were highly valued in cultural life. Childhood and age were structured in relation to prevailing cultural systems, including gerontocracy. Under gerontocracy, West African groups defined children as dependents and thus subordinate to the head of the household. Adults marked children's advancement and maturity through initiation and rite-of-passage ceremonies, and children demonstrated maturity through spiritual and cultural knowledge that did not necessarily correlate to age.⁴

In records from the Middle Passage and narratives of enslavement, accounts of Black childhood and the treatment of children indicate that people of African descent held different visions of their own childhoods than did people from the dominant European culture. Adults reflected on their childhoods and the ruptures of capture, the Middle Passage, and enslavement in ways that challenged European models of childhood. Olaudah Equiano and Ottobah Cugoano, for example, reveal in their autobiographies that childhood in Africa was a distinct stage of life marked by playful behavior. Beyond recounting that age was marked by moons in Agimaque, present-day Ghana, Cugoano described adults treating children in ways that did not delineate between labor and play.⁵ Adults viewed children's work as an essential element of precolonial African life; however, children incorporated play into their lives after they completed domestic and economic tasks. Their play and leisure included unsupervised physical activities outdoors in addition to culturally significant activities, including participation in folktales, music, and dance.

Writers like Equiano and Cugoano influenced and reframed ideas about Black childhood by emphasizing how drastically European enslavers had altered their childhoods. Equiano wrote of his capture as the moment in which “an end was put to my happiness” at the age of eleven—he was then kidnapped and sold into slavery while at play with other children.⁶ Cugoano also described his capture as one in which he was “brought from a state of innocence and freedom, and, in a barbarous and cruel manner, conveyed to

a state of horror and slavery.”⁷ Equiano, Cugoana, as well as other writers of African descent in the New World, used their autobiographies to frame and conceptualize African childhood by highlighting distinctions between the experiences of children and adults in West Africa—and by describing the moment of rupture caused by capture and enslavement.⁸

The transatlantic slave trade disrupted prevailing treatment of children and youth in ways that “streamlined, simplified, and erased the nuance and complexity of African childhood.”⁹ As scholar Sowande’ Mustakeem demonstrates, children of the Middle Passage were viewed by captives and enslavers alike as outside the social category of childhood—as “imagined bodies” of future labor.¹⁰ Enslavers attempted to remake African children into enslaved bodies while they remade the Eurocentric ideas of childhood through opposition to West African cultural beliefs.

Autobiographies of the Middle Passage make clear that children’s behavior, in particular humanizing actions like crying and playing, were restricted by enslavers. In one egregious instance aboard a slave ship, enslavers forced a captive woman to throw her crying infant overboard. The dehumanizing treatment of children during the Middle Passage was a “process of making and unmaking Black bodies.”¹¹ Enslavers’ construction of the physical spaces in the early stages of enslavement—the slave ship, the sea, and the Middle Passage—reframed the boundaries of childhood to exclude Black children.

African-descended ideas about childhood established in West Africa and the Middle Passage conflicted with emerging notions of childhood in the United States. During the antebellum era in the United States, constructions of childhood evolved to encourage white children’s play and leisure in the domestic sphere. Middle-class white adults granted children permission to play as part of their schooling and domestic life. This evolution reflected changing settings and cultural attitudes towards children that resulted from industrialization, the public school reform movement, and changing demographics.¹² However, social structures and economic circumstances limited the playful exploration of poor children and children of color, who often played outdoors in spaces that were not designated for children, such as streets in urban cities. Meanwhile, middle-class white children played indoors under adult supervision and with age-appropriate objects.¹³ Northern Black children were directly impacted by this racialized approach to play in the nineteenth century, as dominant society structured the culture of childhood in ways that marked Black children as other.

Scholars have offered various depictions of enslaved Black children’s play that range from the restricted and violent to romanticized views that the

plantation environment offered unique opportunities. Eugene Genovese constructed the plantation scene as one filled “with woods and streams to explore and to provide a setting for mischievous adventures.” Enslaved children, argues Genovese, “did not have to rely as much as children in crowded urban environments on formal games to amuse themselves.”¹⁴ Bernard Mergen, however, challenges the notion that enslaved children were allotted unrestricted time to play, citing the lack of memories about play reflected within the narratives of enslavement collected as part of the Works Progress Administration (WPA) during the 1930s. Within the collection, only 10 percent of those interviewed mentioned play.¹⁵ Wilma King’s expansive study on nineteenth-century childhood describes play under slavery as “a voluntary, enjoyable, and liberating activity” that was not an uncharacteristic aspect of the enslaved experience. King provides a nuanced perspective of the ways in which children’s leisure became an inventive and imaginative space for resisting the oppressive nature of slavery. King argues that role-playing games “taught children the values and morals of the adult world.”¹⁶ Similarly, David Wiggins addresses the play activities of enslaved children during the antebellum era in ways that highlight play’s function within the establishment of the enslaved Black community. Wiggins argues that play and leisure allowed children to learn literacy, connect with peers, and manage the trauma of slavery.¹⁷

The childhoods and play of antebellum northern Black children were similar in that Black children were inherently marginalized as a result of the social and economic composition of the urban North. Northern cities in the United States experienced growth in their populations of African Americans during the early part of the nineteenth century as a result of emancipation and migration. New York City’s free African American population grew by more than 600 percent from 1790 to 1810, from 2,500 Black residents to 7,000.¹⁸ In 1800, African Americans accounted for 10.53 percent, 10.33 percent, and 4.71 percent of the total population in New York, Philadelphia, and Boston, respectively. Black children in these cities were a small minority of that population.¹⁹

Following industrialization, the majority of northern African American children lived in urban environments. Black children held important roles in the households of northern whites, often serving as domestics alongside their parents. However, Black children in the antebellum North were often orphaned by the process of enslavement, economic subjugation, and social and legal discrimination, and thus did not have parental supervision and

protection for their play. Moreover, reformers categorically defined Black children as orphans, regardless of their actual parentage status. Black children were considered “orphans” whether one parent or both parents had died, or even if both parents were alive.

This inconsistent usage of the category of the “orphan” existed as one of slavery’s afterlives. Orphan status was, as Hortense Spillers has described, one way that children existed “on the boundary,” where “human and familial status, by the very nature of the case, had yet to be defined.” Black children were suspended in a space where “‘kinship’ loses meaning, since it can be invaded at any given and arbitrary moment by the property relations.”²⁰ In the antebellum North, African American children’s identities as children were simultaneously shaped by this invasion of family ties due to the process of enslavement and by the changing socioeconomic statuses and material conditions that accompanied gradual emancipation.

In the nineteenth century, many Black children who lived and labored in the cities of the urban North were still either enslaved or indentured. They did not experience the abrupt rupture in play caused by entering into the workforce of plantation field labor, but they also did not have consistent access to formalized play throughout their childhoods.²¹ Instead, their behavior was closely monitored through intimate proximity to their enslavers or indenturers as they labored in urban households. By contrast, northern children who lived in rural settings and were enslaved or worked on smaller-scale plantations had some access to cultural events where the Black community protected and fostered children’s play and leisure, including New York and New Jersey’s Pinkster celebration.²² However, whites surveilled these celebrations and criminalized participation.²³ In all settings, urban and rural, Black children therefore resisted proslavery ideology and their own commodification by enacting forms of play in the face of emerging racist discourse on childhood and Blackness.²⁴

Pseudoscientific discourse on race also marked Black children as deviant in ways that affected their access to play. The racist literature of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries was impacted by gradual emancipation, the Industrial Revolution, urbanization, and the growth of reform movements. Popular ideas about Black childhood followed racist notions of Black inferiority that were initially produced in Thomas Jefferson’s *Notes on the State of Virginia* (1781). Such notions were then elaborated on and widely accepted by the nineteenth century. In 1849, Charles Lyell argued that Black children “up to the age of fourteen . . . advance as fast as white, but

after that age, unless there be an admixture of white blood, it becomes, in most instances, extremely difficult to carry them forward.”²⁵ The idea that Black childhood development stagnated—which in turn infantilized Black adulthood—greatly impacted popular culture. Media, literature, and products for children’s play adopted these views, as did objects of childhood development such as games and toys.²⁶

Both adults and children reinforced the racialization of American childhood. White dominant society designed objects of play in ways that privileged white childhood innocence and projected Black criminality and deviance, and white children normalized these racist characterizations in their play.²⁷ Toys were produced in mass-cultural form during the second part of the nineteenth century in response to evolving notions of play, middle-class identity, and consumer culture. As the middle-class values shifted away from preindustrial notions of childhood and toward those of modern childhood and the value of childhood experiences, children’s play took on new meaning. Children’s book writer Jacob Abbot and educational reformer William A. Alcott, for example, produced literature on children’s moral education that constructed childhood as a developmental stage in which play should be cultivated. And by the 1830s, urban children had begun to play predominantly indoors. Following this trend, toy manufacturers created playful objects that encouraged domestic play, even as the nature of play shifted to become more violent and unfettered. Within this context, manufacturers designed toys in ways that encouraged racialized play—with white children enacting scenes of violence and learning white supremacy through the process.²⁸

A paper doll set produced by the McLoughlin Brothers is one clear example of how racialized ideas infused objects of play (see figure 1.1). The McLoughlin Brothers’ children’s books, prints, and toys were highly popular during this era, with the company especially recognized for its use of color printing in children’s toys. This paper doll set depicting Eva and Topsy from Harriet Beecher Stowe’s *Uncle Tom’s Cabin* was produced just as the book catapulted to mass popularity.²⁹ The dolls constructed whiteness as neutral and Blackness as other, and normalized Eva’s essentialized innocence and Topsy’s deviance. The pale skin of Eva on the cover of the box reflects the base color of the box itself, though it is texturized with flashes of red, a juxtaposition that serves to render her otherwise translucent skin human but childlike with a blushed hue. By contrast, Topsy’s skin is dark brown and is texturized by rough lines. She has red lips and earrings, images that are characteristic of blackface minstrelsy, the popular nineteenth-century racist performance.



FIGURE 1.1 Eva St. Claire and Topsy paper dolls (New York: McLoughlin Bros., ca. 1870). American Antiquarian Society.



The neutral figures of Eva and Topsy before they are dressed also indicate subtle but powerful expressions of racialized childhood. Eva stands with her arms gently crossed at her waist, stepping slightly forward, gazing slightly off center as if deep in thought. After she is dressed, she holds either a bouquet of flowers or a book. Topsy stands with her arms tightly crossed across her midsection and stares directly at the observer or the child at play. Her shirt hangs off her shoulders, her dress is torn, and her shoes are untied. When clothed, Topsy continues to enact body language that is either removed or timid, clutching her clothing tightly. The dolls prescribe play that reinforces the association of Eva with innocence, while Topsy's image invites a sexual gaze that denies her equal treatment and recognition as a child. In accordance with the novel, Topsy can only attempt to mimic the childhood purity that Eva embodies.

Although children might attempt to engage with these objects differently than their producers intended by placing the clothing intended for Eva on Topsy, they would only succeed in damaging the clothing or the dolls themselves; both the dolls and the clothes were designed in such a way that they could only fit their respective subjects. Specifically, Topsy's underdress, for example, is still visible when covered by Eva's, shorter garments. Topsy's dresses do not fit onto Eva due to the shape of Eva's head, a large, round form that appears exaggerated next to Topsy's. Eva has a neat pink bow in her hair that is accentuated by the wearing of her bonnets. Topsy's hair, standing out in many directions, is veiled completely by her hats and headscarf. Topsy's hair also prevents a child from fitting Eva's bonnets neatly on her head.

The design of the Eva and Topsy paper dolls reflected the ideology of white childhood as normative. Indeed, literature, images, and toys that promoted the idea of Black childhood deviance were almost inescapable for white children during the nineteenth century. However, through their play, this construction was made real: embodied and performed acts of play that initiated and encouraged racialized discrimination and violence. And through the act of placing and removing clothing on two oppositional figures, the children who played with the paper dolls of Eva and Topsy enacted a version of racialized childhood that was cultivated by white parents but denied to African American children.

While white children's play was encouraged and then racialized through interactions with toys, society perceived African American children's play as deviant. Furthermore, play posed a real danger for Black northern children who were sometimes kidnapped and sold into slavery during joyous and playful moments. In 1828, for example, whites kidnapped the child James Dailey

in Pennsylvania while he played with his friends. Enslavers sold him into southern slavery in Louisiana, where his enslaver whipped him repeatedly and starved him. The Philadelphia high constable, Samuel Garrigues, intervened after he was made aware of the capture—likely through the work of Black activists and abolitionists—and successfully called for Dailey’s return to Philadelphia. The violence the child endured in Louisiana was so severe that he was “far gone” when he returned and was sent to the Philadelphia Almshouse for his injuries. He died eight days later.³⁰ Black children lived in constant fear of kidnapping, particularly as former enslavers were forced to end their economic ties to slavery following gradual emancipation and in the years prior to the Civil War. These instances of capture impacted Black children’s ability to play and their psychological relationship to play.

Meanwhile, the free Black community produced various opinions on the proper play of Black children, which they published in African American newspapers. Although the concept of play had not yet garnered the level of attention it would later in the nineteenth century, these publications demonstrate that African Americans contemplated the meaning of play in the Black child’s world in ways that regulated respectable childhood. In February 1839, the *Colored American* published an advice column to parents, titled “Family Reading,” that encouraged them to fill children’s leisure time with “amusing and useful reading.” The article further instructed parents that although they might believe they could not afford books, they should “take but two meals a day” in order to “imbue the minds of children with an ardent desire for useful knowledge.”³¹ An article titled “The Infant Knowledge System,” which the *Colored American* published in October of the same year, provided an even more assertive recommendation regarding children’s play and leisure. The author countered the claim that children should be educated early—“shortly after the children are weaned”—by asking readers, “Is this wholesome—is it natural? Is it fair—is it humane, that a child should be cheated out of its childhood and sent to learn the ‘use of the globes’ before it has learnt to play at marbles? . . . Oh! In place of sending a child to school three or four years, let it enjoy three or four more years of healthy ignorance.”³²

African American authors, middle-class adults in particular, responded to and subverted idealizations of children’s play in their representations of free and enslaved childhood during the antebellum era. The relationship between “respectable” play and the material conditions of play is exemplified in the work of activist and author Susan Paul. Paul was an early advocate for Black children through her work as a teacher and choir director. She was born into a prominent Black religious family with ties to the abolitionist movement.

Paul taught at Boston's African American Primary School No. 6 and at Baptist Sunday school, and was the director of the Garrison Juvenile Choir. After her sister passed away, she took in her four children. Throughout her life, Paul consistently placed children at the center of her personal and economic concerns and identified the plight and well-being of African American children as a site for further activism.³³

The African American children who were taught by Susan Paul participated in forms of recreation that included artistic expression and music as singers in her juvenile choir. The choir first performed for the New England Anti-Slavery Society in 1833 and continued until 1837. Made up of Paul's schoolroom students, the group combined singing with activism as they sang for abolitionist conventions and events throughout Boston and Salem. The children's choir was therefore actively political, and while for some children the activity may not have been one of leisure, the choir served to challenge the exploitation of Black children's labor and their exclusion from equal schooling. The children sang many explicitly political songs, but also sang one titled "The Garden," in which they celebrated "the joys of the classroom" and their "devotion to their teacher."³⁴

In addition to forming the juvenile choir, Susan Paul published the biography *Memoir of James Jackson: The Attentive and Obedient Scholar, Who Died in Boston, October 31, 1833, Aged Six Years and Eleven Months* (1835). The text, an early representation of an emergent discourse on northern Black childhood, was published through the aid of Boston printer James Loring after Paul was turned away by the American Sunday School Union. The memoir is the first of its kind and documents the life of a young African American child, James Jackson, who grew up in Boston and died just before his seventh birthday. Paul, who was born into a legacy of free African American intellectuals and activists, penned the memoir as a didactic religious document. A popular style for juvenile audiences during the early nineteenth century, it aimed to educate both Black and white children and parents. The book's content—a description of the life of a nonelite northern Black child—and its material construction in a small size designed for children's hands, indicate that it held special significance for African American children. It exists as an artifact of both instruction and play.³⁵

Critical interrogation of James Jackson's biography not only provides a portrait of antebellum northern African American childhood, it simultaneously challenges both pejorative white ideas about Black childhood and countervailing constructions of respectable Black childhood. The narrative

details Jackson's life, his relationship with his mother, and his religious education. Although historians have unearthed significant background on Susan Paul, relatively little is known about James Jackson. Census data collected in 1820 indicates that the Jacksons lived on South Russell Street in Boston and that James lived with his mother, two brothers, two sisters, and father until his father's death in 1827 or 1828. As a Black child with only one working parent and no relation to one of Boston's very few relatively middle-class Black families, James Jackson was representative of the vast majority of northern working-class African American children.³⁶

Jackson attended Boston's Primary School No. 6, where he and Susan Paul formed the relationship that she portrayed in his biography.³⁷ Paul documented James Jackson's life as a student, his relationship with his teacher and his mother, his social inclinations, and his early death. As a literary text, the *Memoir of James Jackson* exhibits many of the trends typical of nineteenth-century writing, such as didactic spiritual moralism including a religious awakening and a fearless confrontation with illness and death. Paul constructed Black childhood as innocent, religiously pure, and intellectually mature. The memoir's preface directly addresses parents, encouraging them to "store the minds of children committed to them with religious truth." Paul also wrote directly to children throughout the body of the text. While modeling appropriate Black childhood behavior, she challenged notions of racial inferiority and inherent Black deviance.³⁸

According to Paul, Jackson's early childhood was marked by his interest in school and his pious spirit. Paul emphasized Jackson's obedience even when his mother insisted he cease playing and put away his toys. She imbued his biography with ideas about childhood, asserting that all children would "have been pleased to have seen little James, only three years old, running about so happy, and so kindly telling his mother some little tale." Indeed, Paul underscored Jackson's happiness through his desire to please his mother.³⁹ This expression of childhood was in line with popular ideas about Black childhood and motherhood in the Black press, which emphasized Black women's role in the education of their children.⁴⁰

Reflecting Susan Paul's idealized vision of Black childhood, the activities that pleased Jackson were not those that were typically associated with the "carefree" nature of childhood. Paul claimed that Jackson was intellectually gifted and desired to attend school earlier than normal, for example. Admission to primary school usually occurred at age four, but Jackson, who exhibited good behavior and advanced intelligence, was admitted at age three. Adult observers, his family in particular, were troubled by Jackson's apparent

devotion to his studies. Jackson claimed that he would rather stay with his mother than play with “bad boys.” His mother, however, encouraged him to play, “fearing he would suffer for want of exercise.” As represented by Paul, James Jackson behaved how he wanted to learn and play. This, however, concerned the adults in his life—his teachers and his mother. His true desires were filtered through the lens of adult observation, Black respectability, and racialized childhood.

In her representation of James Jackson, Susan Paul challenged nineteenth-century depictions of Black children as wicked and deviant. As a strategy to foreground Jackson’s innocence, she overemphasized his maturity and naivety without directly referencing any inclination toward play. Jackson’s innocence was represented as Christian spiritualism and racial ignorance.⁴¹ Jackson was, according to Paul, “under the special influence of his gracious Spirit.”⁴² Paul took pains to demonstrate the ways in which Jackson’s nature was “not like the disposition which children commonly exhibit.” Paul expressed Jackson’s desire to abstain from work on the Sabbath as a demonstration of his commitment to his spiritualism. She documented a day when Jackson told his mother he did not want to assist her in grinding coffee by pleading, “Well, ma, is not this the Sabbath?” to which his mother responded, “Well, James, you need not grind the coffee if you feel so about it.”⁴³ While Jackson’s response indicates the commitment to Christianity and spiritual innocence illustrated by Paul, it also simultaneously demonstrates a desire not to work. This exchange is the only place in the memoir where Jackson’s chores were mentioned specifically, and he chose *not* to do them. This passage was reprinted in the “New Works” section of the *Liberator* on August 1, 1835, in an anonymous letter to the editor, as a demonstration of the powerful articulations of childhood found within the text.

Both Susan Paul and James Jackson confronted the limitations of the legibility of Black childhood. Paul represented Jackson as a respectable, religiously innocent child, and James Jackson exhibited behavior in order to be recognized as a Black child. Similarly, other northern Black children encountered the metaphysical dilemma of being perceived as and enjoying social recognition as a Black child. This dilemma was exacerbated for Black girls, who were expected to perform childhood in ways that were simultaneously racialized and gendered. Zilpha Elaw, a Black woman who came of age in the antebellum North, produced a memoir of her childhood and life and in particular her play and labor. *Memoirs of the Life, Religious Experience, Ministerial Travels and Labours of Mrs. Zilpha Elaw*, published in London in 1846, offers

a similar experience of religious expression and spiritual conversion.⁴⁴ Although studies of the memoir have focused on its depiction of Black spirituality and womanhood, it is also significant for revealing the tension between racialized children's play in the North and religious expression.⁴⁵

Elaw's memoir provides a glimpse into the ways in which free African American laboring children conceptualized play. After the death of her mother when Zilpha Elaw was only twelve, Zilpha was indentured to a Quaker family.⁴⁶ While she labored for the Quaker family of Pierson and Rebecca Mitchel, her father died. After the death of her father, Elaw began to associate joyful and childish times spent among the Quaker children with guilt.⁴⁷ Though she mentioned being "very young" at the time, Elaw was ashamed to associate with the "juvenile members of the family," whose "childish conversations" caused her to feel "exceedingly sinful."⁴⁸ Elaw claimed that she overcame the follies of childhood through religious devotion. She internalized a notion of childhood that excluded her from embodying the behavior exhibited by her white child-peers. Though it is possible that she was older than these children and closer to an age at which girls were considered women, she referred to these children as "childish companions."⁴⁹ Elaw considered their childish behavior as an experience that distanced her from God. She did not describe any of the specific labor activities that she or the other children engaged in, but she conceptualized her position in the home, as well as her spirituality, as precarious in ways that excluded her from exhibiting similar playful behavior similar to theirs. Like the depiction of James Jackson's apparent disinterest in play, Elaw's memoir demonstrates the ways in which Black girls were forced to observe white children's play without being permitted to participate. In turn, Elaw and Jackson learned and internalized what constituted appropriate and respectable Black religious and childhood expression.

REFORMERS AND TEACHERS REINFORCED respectable play through their presentation of gifts and by encouraging leisure activities. In 1829, white Quaker and abolitionist Abigail Mott produced an abridged version of Olaudah Equiano's narrative for the African American students at the New York Manumission School. She conceived of the book as a reward for the good behavior of the students at the school, which used a ticket system to allow children to purchase prizes. After observing the children at the school, Abigail Mott claimed, "There is scarcely any thing which can be given to a child as a premium for behavior which has a better tendency than a book. This belief prompted me to attempt an abridgement of the Memoirs of Gustavus Vassa, the African."⁵⁰

The edited version of Equiano's narrative simplified much of the original autobiography and included illustrations and reflections on African childhood by Equiano himself.⁵¹ Mott's textual and visual representations of Equiano in the juvenile version, as well as her stated justification for its publication, exist as a reflection of how northern Black children and their play were treated. Through Mott's text, Black children interacted with Equiano's representation of African and African Diasporic childhood, in particular his reflections on his life in Africa and the play, trauma, and loss he endured during capture and enslavement. These experiences resonated with the students, whose lives were also marked by slavery, violence, and surveillance.

Black children's play was also monitored and controlled through the production of Mott's book. Mott believed that the book would be a more appropriate reward for good behavior than toys, which the children were already exchanging with one another. The production of the juvenile version of Equiano's text was meant to influence the children's reward system and, in doing so, both acknowledged Black children's playful desires and interrupted them. Mott's judgment of what ought to be objects of Black children's enjoyment was one way in which white reformers, teachers, and abolitionists sought to control Black children through their play and pleasure.

Reformers also surveilled Black children's play in private orphanages for Black children. In their annual reports, reformers documented the children's (dis)interest in and possession of objects of play. They instead highlighted and praised children's studiousness and piety, as in the case of Stephen Ricks. According to the 1842 annual report by the Association for the Care of Coloured Orphans in Philadelphia, the institution did not allocate specific funds for objects designed for play. Rather, they received donations of miscellaneous objects ranging from clothing and books to pencils and paper, and, notably, a map of Africa.⁵² In 1856, the Philadelphia Home for Destitute Colored Children documented that among the numerous donations it received were "toys and candles" donated by Martha Griscom.⁵³ These items were not priorities in what was requested or purchased by reformers, who instead stressed that the children came from "extreme poverty" and therefore only required bare necessities.

While the institutions for Black children rarely invested in toys, they did allocate space for play. Reformers increasingly perceived outdoor play as a necessity during the nineteenth century, and the Shelter for Coloured Orphans in Philadelphia acknowledged the children's need for recreation to "a reasonable extent."⁵⁴ The creation of physical spaces for play by various or-

phanages for Black children in Philadelphia anticipated later developments in institutionalized recreation. Theories that advocated outdoor fitness emerged at a later period, and were primarily a product of the twentieth century. In this context, theorists, mainly German, advocated the creation of specific places for play for outdoor fitness, contributing to the playground movement in the United States in the late nineteenth century. Theorist Friedrich Froebel, for example, promoted the concept of kindergartens, a child-centered space designated for the physical, mental, and emotional development of the child.⁵⁵

Prior to this development, adults granted children outdoor space for recreation at reformatories and schools, but the need for such spaces was not universally accepted, and they were not always made available to children of different backgrounds.⁵⁶ The authors of the 1840 annual report of the Shelter for Coloured Orphans in Philadelphia celebrated its relocation to a new residence that provided the children with better ventilation in their rooms and “sufficient ground for recreation and exercise, with a large play-room in the basement, for their accommodation in wet weather.” This new space became a source of pride for the orphanage. The reformers claimed that in providing the “poor orphans” with outdoor space, they gifted them “comfort,” “enjoyment,” and “liberality.” This was in contrast to “the suffering and destitution which would probably have been their lot, had not this home been provided for them.”⁵⁷ Reformers clearly placed a high value on the space allowed for play as a form of proper child-rearing which they believed many Black parents would otherwise be unable to provide their children.

Photographic records of the Colored Orphan Asylum of New York indicate that children at this institution were also granted space, physical and temporal, for play. The four-story building, which housed hundreds of children in two wings, had a courtyard where they could play. One famous photograph captures at least sixty children, all dressed alike and seemingly mainly young girls, frozen in a state of near-play (see figure 1.2). Many held hoops for recreational games. Another photograph indicates that the asylum also had a recreation room for the children, with a swing and rocking chairs (see figure 1.3). It shows children posed with objects of play alongside their teachers or matrons, one of whom holds a young infant in her arms as she sits in a rocking chair. These images indicate that the administrators of the asylum prioritized the recreation of the children enough to allocate space and objects to encourage and enable their play and amusement. They also demonstrate how Black children participated in behavior and activity beyond the outlines of the institution’s published



FIGURE 1.2 Colored Orphan Asylum girls' playground. Jeffrey Kraus Collection.

reports, in which reformers typically only highlighted the children's education and vocational training.

Stephen Ricks was one of very few orphaned children whose thoughts and feelings about their play were documented by reformers. Stephen spent only one and a half years at the Shelter for Coloured Orphans in Philadelphia alongside his brothers Simon and Henry before he died. The administrators memorialized his remarkable life in their 1836 annual report. Stephen's amusements, as described by the authors, included his ability to "draw from memory the map of the United States," with "so much neatness and ingenuity, that some of the performances are now highly valued by those who knew the author, as mementos of the rare talents of this intelligent boy of colour."⁵⁸ This sketch of Stephen Ricks's personality and skill was then reproduced in the juvenile antislavery periodical *The Slave's Friend*. The author of the arti-



FIGURE 1.3 Colored Orphan Asylum playroom. Jeffrey Kraus Collection.

cle “The Shelter for Colored Orphans,” published in 1836, claimed to have observed Stephen Rick’s map personally while on a visit to the orphanage. The author noted that all the children were “so neat, and gentle, and obedient,” and that there was a map on display “drawn from memory, by a little colored boy about seven years old.” The author relayed to the child readers that Stephen Ricks had now “gone to his Heavenly Father.”⁵⁹

Stephen Ricks’s memorial included a “joyful-death,” which scholar Ivy Linton Stabell identifies as a literary trope that was similarly developed in Susan Paul’s biography of James Jackson.⁶⁰ Ricks’s death, the cause of which was recorded publicly as pulmonary complication or consumption, occurred after failed attempts at medical intervention. At the end of his life, observers claimed that the child was “mild, sedate, and reflective” and that he fully embraced his religious and spiritual practice. The memorial describes how “toward the close of life he occasionally rehearsed pious sentiments, and repeated passages of scripture as they occurred in recollection.” He also

mourned the death of his younger brother, “not like the short-lived grief of childhood, which may be, and often is, wept into forgetfulness;—on the contrary, his sorrow was serious and lasting.” Reformers documented that Stephen Ricks’s behavior “could not fail to engage the compassionate regard of the superintending association,” in part because this behavior was expressed “in a subject so young.”⁶¹ It was these qualities—how he lived his life and approached his death—that the administrators highly valued, especially when expressed by a young Black boy.

After Stephen Ricks’s death, a poem he had written to another orphan, Mary Walton, was discovered inside Mary’s workbox. Posthumously titled “Stephen to Mary,” the poem was published in *The Slave’s Friend* in 1836. It is a powerful and profound expression of Ricks’s feelings of mourning and loss. In it, Stephen Ricks credits Mary Walton with teaching him not to fear death. He identifies throughout the poem as a child, colored, and an orphan. He requests that Mary “lead a little orphan band to this bright, celestial land, where the colored people share in redeeming mercy fair.” Heaven will be his ultimate “shelter,” a blissful and peaceful home.⁶²

The poem exists as a material example of Stephen Ricks’s leisure activities and reinforces the behavior suggested by the reformers: that he did indeed favor “retirement with pen” over play. However, it also expresses feelings that fit within the dominant discourse around Black childhood and may have been edited by the adult reformers. In any case, even if these words were not entirely Stephen Ricks’s, it is likely that he did leave a message to a fellow playmate and child Mary. In doing so, Ricks inserted himself into the record of Black childhood.

While the reports and publications produced by antebellum organizations that educated and cared for northern Black children typically did not include such expressions of the internal thoughts and feelings of African American orphans directly, the private records of association members and other educational documents provide further glimpses into African American children’s lives. As members of the Association for the Care of Coloured Orphans, for example, individual white women had direct interactions with northern African American children during the antebellum period that shaped their involvement in reform and abolitionism. One family that worked closely with the association, the Morris family of Philadelphia, was an elite white Quaker family whose Pennsylvanian roots dated back to the seventeenth century. They were owners of a brewing company and active as humanitarians.⁶³ The Morris Family Papers contain records of the Association for Coloured Orphans, including the minutes of its first meeting. The

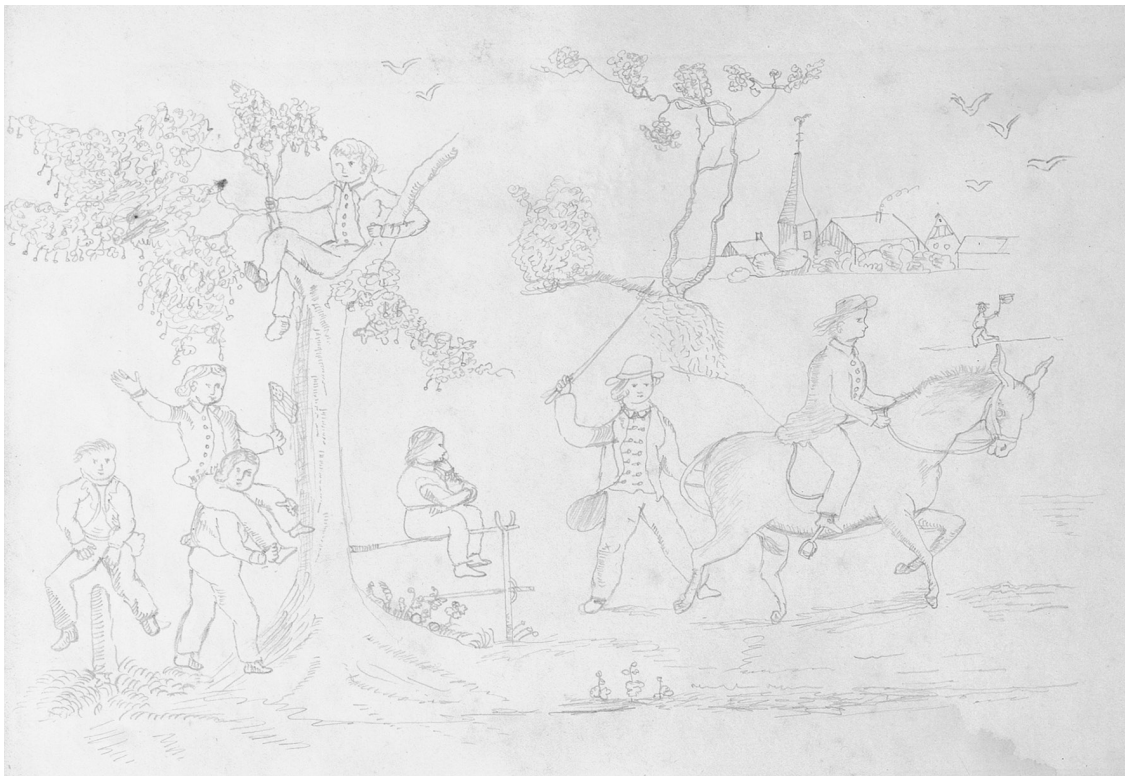


FIGURE 1.4 Morris family sketch of playing children. Morris Family Papers, Historical Society of Pennsylvania. Reproduced with permission from the Historical Society of Pennsylvania.

collection also houses a sketchbook, circa 1865, containing portraits of family members and vivid depictions of children at play (see figure 1.4). The drawing was most likely composed by Hannah or Luke Morris, two of the children of the household, and includes children embarking in many playful outdoor activities in the rural setting in which the Morris family lived outside of Philadelphia.

In one drawing (figure 1.5), two of the children of the household—Hannah and Luke Morris, aged eleven and seven, respectively—play “blind man’s buff [sic]” with a young girl identified as Rachel, who appears to be of color. The game of blindman’s bluff involved one child, in this case Hannah, searching for the other children while blindfolded. The game is represented in the sketch at the moment when Hannah has just found Rachel and is tugging on her apron string. Rachel and Hannah appear to be similar in age, but Rachel’s clothing distinguishes her from Hannah and “Lutie.” She wears an apron, does not have any decorative features like Hannah’s bow, and her skirt is longer. Rachel was most likely a servant or an



FIGURE 1.5 Morris family sketch of children playing blindman's bluff. Morris Family Papers, Historical Society of Pennsylvania. Reproduced with permission from the Historical Society of Pennsylvania.

indentured laborer for the Morris family or a neighboring household. However, in this sketch, she is both working as a servant *and* playing.

Northern African American children who were indentured, like Rachel and Zilpha Elaw, played within the confines of bound labor. The drawing represents fugitive elements of Black children's play, and also demonstrates the likely relationships between interracial child's play and the humanitarianism embraced by the Morris family. Hannah's Great Aunt Beulah Sansom was involved in reform work and was one of the founding members of the Shelter for Coloured Orphans in Philadelphia, where Stephen Ricks lived until his death. Hannah Morris eventually joined the Association for the Care of Coloured Orphans as an annual subscriber to the shelter's reports.⁶⁴ Rachel may have been connected to the family through their involvement in the orphanage.

The sketchbook reflects society's evolving treatment of play and of African American children, who by the second half of the nineteenth century were strategically fugitive with their play. Northern African Americans similarly fought for recognition of Black childhood through their play at work, at school, and at orphanages. In these settings, debates over the nature of childhood were expressed in negotiations over the ways in which Black children should or should not play. Although playful behavior was increas-

ingly identified as an essential part of childhood, for many African American children and authors of texts on Black childhood, the proper embodiment of play was a negotiated and complicated behavior—like the “serious” and “lasting sorrow” Stephen Ricks expressed when mourning his brother, which was seen as evidence of his unchildlike demeanor and maturity. In these constructions, authors sometimes resisted negative portrayals of Black childhood by deemphasizing the playful leisure activities of Black children. Ricks was memorialized for existing in a space beyond childhood.

Northern African American children like Stephen Ricks, James Jackson, Zilpha Elaw, and the enigmatic Rachel—as well as how they played—stood in stark contrast to the play presented in popular children’s literature and toys intended for use by white middle-class children. Some reformers viewed play as a means of regulating the behavior of Black children, while Black activists used play as a means of controlling the perception of Black children. Free African American children, however, navigated these contradictions by *playing down* their leisure activities, while white children embraced them.

Black children’s play and imaginative behavior directly challenged the emerging limitations placed up on them as children, laborers, and future citizens. Through their behavior and play, antebellum northern Black children faced the metaphysical dilemma of childhood and entered the negotiated process of expressing freedom. Their institutionalization and movement into (and out of) spaces designated for children, including orphanages and homes for juvenile delinquents, operated as one of the ways in which Black childhood was defined throughout the nineteenth century. While Black children sought to play in ways that were legible to dominant society, the adults around them sought new forms of social and economic control through the regulation of their labor.